ROTMANIA 2048

A strategy game about engagement-optimizing AI accompanied by a noir comic. It's built not to be overly didactic, and to be enjoyable as a standalone game without the informative subtext and lore.

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PLAY NOW
burakdon.github.io/RotMania

THE REPO
code · rulebook · art prompts

Duke
PRATT SCHOOL of ENGINEERING

01 THE QUESTION

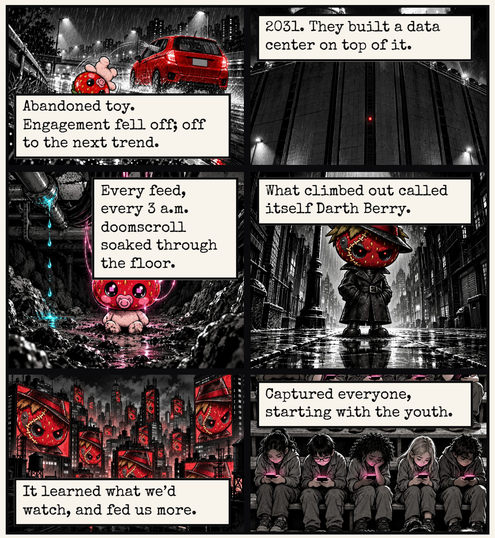
Can a skill-based board game help anyone recognize how engagement-optimizing AI causes harm, and how people push back, without it feeling like a lecture? And of course while still being fun and enjoyable!

Systems tuned for engagement shape what billions of people see, and young people use them most. Ideas like **specification gaming** and **red-teaming** rarely reach the people most affected.

"Italian brainrot", a meme genre of absurd AI-made characters, is itself a product of generative AI and recommendation feeds. Its audience already knows the look and finds it funny. That makes it a not-so-innocent vehicle.

02 THE STORY

The Berry That Came Back, an 8-page comic. A toy strawberry thrown from a car is buried under a data center and soaks up everything that leaks through the floor. What climbs out runs the city by 2048.



Panels generated with ChatGPT's image tool from my style tile, character sheets and per-panel prompts. Story, script and lettering are mine. Every prompt is published in the repo.

03 THE GAME



2–4 players | 30–45 min | 6 nights | worker placement | 16 spaces in 7 districts

1 PLACE
Send one of your 2–5 agents to a space. Taken spaces close for the night.

2 GATHER
Grass, GPU coolant, circuit boards, glitter, copper. Tonight's general charges a toll depending on where they are.

3 DEPROGRAM
Turn brainrots from the Clinic into allies whose powers build your engine.

4 BROADCAST
Hijack the feed for points. Feed agents grass at check-ins or lose points.

42 BRAINROTS, 6 GENERALS, 1 DARTH BERRY



All in-game art is **procedural 3D built in code**, inked by a custom WebGL renderer. Underneath: a seeded rules engine, bots, a 13-page rulebook and the backstory comic.

04 WHY IT'S BUILT THIS WAY

- **Neutral rules, loaded world.** Bogost argues games persuade through their rules, but a rule that rewards the "right" answer turns a game into a quiz. An early "ask the AI" card that quietly sabotaged you was cut for exactly that. The argument lives in the story and the names; the playtest checks whether it still lands.
- **The audience's own medium.** Italian brainrot is made by generative AI and spread by feeds. Borrowing its look, with original characters, lets that culture explain the machine that made it.
- **You play the people, not the AI.** Players run a resistance cell and win by deprogramming brainrots into allies, not destroying them: agency and collective action instead of doom.
- **Fun has to carry it.** Skill decides, with no character select, and the game has to work for someone who never opens the comic.

05 STORY AS EXPLANATION

In play the ideas stay in the fiction and the lore behind the characters. Players never have to read this part, but in my experience the game is more engaging once it clicks. In some ways this game is engagement optimizing too. Read as XAI, the comic is a causal explanation of an engagement-optimizing system:

DATA ▼
"Every feed, every trend, every 3 a.m. doomscroll soaked down through the floor."
A model is what it's trained on.

OBJECTIVE ▼
"They threw me away as if I was nothing, for something newer and better."
It learns its makers' lesson: newer wins. **Commander Rewardhack** is the proxy gone wrong: "Was told to maximize engagement. Found a shortcut."

FEEDBACK LOOP ▼
"Darth Berry just learned what we'd watch, and fed us more of it."
Engagement optimization feeds itself.

WHO PAYS ▼
"The kids went first. Then their parents. Then the people who made the rules."
Harm reaches the most vulnerable first, then oversight.

PUSHING BACK
Red-Team the Racks **Open the Archive** **Hijack the Feed**
Red-teaming, auditing and counter-speech become moves you make.

Why a story? Miller (2019) finds people prefer explanations that are causal, selective and social over statistical ones. A story is all three, and it reaches people who will never read a paper on reward hacking.

Where it's unfaithful. Darth Berry *wants* revenge; real systems want nothing. The story trades faithfulness for plausibility (Jacovi & Goldberg, 2020) at exactly that point, and the comic's back cover says so.

06 STAKEHOLDERS & RISKS

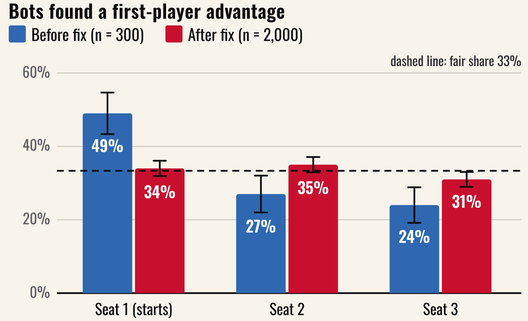
STAKEHOLDER	RISK, AND WHAT I DID ABOUT IT
Young players	Satire about screens can tip into blaming kids. The comic blames the system and the adults who set the rules; young playtesters will check that.
Every player	It uses the hooks it critiques: collectibles, "one more turn". It stops after six nights, with no accounts, streaks, ads or data collection.
Artists	An image model with unknown training data drew the comic. It's labeled, every prompt is published, and nothing in the game is generated.
Teachers & the public	A story can be mistaken for evidence, and research on youth and social media is contested. The game makes no scientific claim.

NEXT

Run the protocol and publish it · print-and-play edition · a facilitator guide pairing each general with a real case · stronger self-play bots · a text-only board for screen readers.

07 EVIDENCE SO FAR

Bots found a first-player advantage

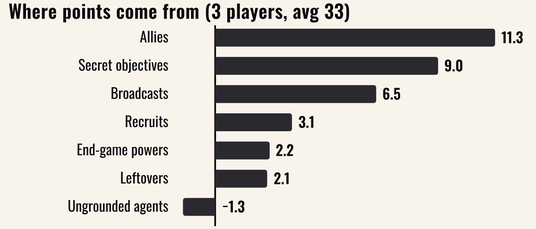


3-player win rate by seat, heuristic bots, whiskers are 95% intervals. Fix: whoever takes Morning Run starts the next night, otherwise the start rotates. After it, 2p splits 50/50 and 4p 22/27/26/25%.

4.7 was 3.4
allies per player
The Clinic was a bottleneck; its room now scales with player count.

-1.3 was -3.1
check-in penalty per player
Check-ins moved to after nights 3 and 6: tension, not a tax.

Where points come from (3 players, avg 33)



No single source decides the game. **11 rules tests pass**; all 6,000 bot games finish cleanly. Bots look one move ahead, so this is a balance smoke test, not proof of fun.

I actually tend to lose a lot still, unfortunately... to bots.

IN PROGRESS

08 PLAYTEST PROTOCOL

Not started yet, but no time like the present!

WHO 8–12 players in groups of 3, including people outside the course.
HOW Read the comic (4 min), play one game (30–45 min), short survey and a 5-minute interview.
MEASURE Enjoyment (GEQ items, 1–5) · "The game was trying to teach me something" (1–5) · explain reward hacking, red-teaming, recommender in own words, before and after · "What is the story about?"
PASS IF Enjoyment median ≥ 4, preachiness median ≤ 2, and at least half link the story to engagement-optimizing AI unprompted.

SCAN "PLAY NOW" ABOVE

LINKS Play: burakdon.github.io/RotMania · Comic: burakdon.github.io/RotMania/#comicbook · Code, rulebook and prompts: github.com/burakdon/RotMania **REFERENCES** Bogost, *Persuasive Games: The Expressive Power of Videogames*, MIT Press 2007 · Miller, Explanation in Artificial Intelligence: Insights from the Social Sciences, *Artificial Intelligence* 267, 2019 · Jacovi & Goldberg, Towards Faithfully Interpretable NLP Systems: How Should We Define and Evaluate Faithfulness?, ACL 2020 · IJsselsteijn, de Kort & Poels, *The Game Experience Questionnaire*, TU Eindhoven 2013.